

BRIGHTHAVEN BAY

ALIGNMENT STARTER GUIDE

A practical first step toward discovering what matters to you—and the possibilities it may reveal.



Inspired by the ideas explored in the novel Brighthaven Bay
by Greg Hoyt

**This guide is not about quitting your job tomorrow or chasing the latest opportunity.
It is about getting clear enough to see possibilities you may have been overlooking.**

A WELCOME FROM CHASE

Before you begin, let's talk about where you're going—and why we're starting with you.

Calling → Direction → Possibilities

Before we get started, I should probably introduce myself.

My name is Chase Carter, and I'm one of the people you'll meet in the novel **Brighthaven Bay**.

When the story begins, I've just walked away from a successful marketing career in Seattle and returned to the small waterfront community where I grew up. I don't come home with some grand plan for what happens next. In fact, I'm trying to answer many of the same questions I'm going to ask you in this guide.

Before long, I find myself teaching a new Digital Communications course at Brighthaven College. What begins as a college class gradually becomes something more. My students aren't just learning about technology and communication. They're trying to figure out what they're good at, what they care about, and what kind of lives they actually want to build.

And somewhere along the way, I begin realizing those questions aren't just for college students.

They're questions almost all of us should probably ask from time to time.

That's why I'm here.

There are three ideas you'll see throughout this guide and the novel: **Calling, Direction, and Possibilities**.

Calling is the pull—the interests, abilities, experiences, or concerns that keep drawing your attention.

Direction begins to emerge when those pieces start pointing toward something that feels worth pursuing.

Possibilities are the different ways that Direction might eventually take shape.

You don't need to know any of those answers yet. That's what we're going to explore together.

If you're holding this guide, there's a good chance something has already started tugging at you.

Maybe you know exactly what it is.

Maybe you don't.

Maybe you have a good job, a family, responsibilities, and a life that looks perfectly fine from the outside—but somewhere along the way, you started wondering whether the path you're on is really the one you want.

Or maybe you've already gone looking for something different.

You've tried a few ideas. Followed some opportunities. Learned about new technology. Maybe even started something more than once, only to find yourself wondering what you should be doing next.

Either way, I want you to do something that may feel a little unusual.

Don't start with the opportunity.

Start with you.

That's what this guide is for.

Throughout *Brighthaven Bay*, you'll meet people at very different places in their lives. Some are just beginning to think about their future. Others have spent years building careers and lives that no longer feel quite right. Some know what they love but have never considered that it might lead somewhere. Others have plenty of skills but no idea what to do with them.

You may recognize a little of yourself in some of them.

And that's where this guide and the story begin to work together.

This guide gives you a place to do some of the exploring yourself. But your journey of self-discovery doesn't end with these pages. Inside the novel, you'll watch students, teachers, families, business owners, and people at very different stages of life wrestle with many of the same questions you're beginning to ask here.

You may see yourself in one of them. You may recognize someone you know. Or a character whose life looks nothing like yours may say or do something that suddenly helps you understand your own life a little differently.

That's one of the reasons I hope you'll experience the story rather than rush through this guide looking for an answer. ***Brighthaven Bay*** isn't a self-help book. It's a novel. You get to spend some time by the water, meet the people who live here, and watch their lives unfold. But underneath the story, something else is happening.

They're discovering things about themselves. And you may discover a few things about yourself right along with them.

The exercises ahead are designed to help you ask some of the same questions they're beginning to ask:

What keeps pulling at you?

What are you already good at?

What have your years of work and life taught you?

What do you care about enough to keep coming back to?

And where might those things be pointing?

You don't need perfect answers.

In fact, I'd be surprised if you had them.

One suggestion before you begin

Keep one clean master copy of this guide.

Print or make another copy to work in now. Then, as you move through *Brighthaven Bay*, come back to these exercises from time to time.

Something a character says may remind you of an interest you've forgotten. Someone else's Direction may make you reconsider your own. An answer that seems obvious today may look completely different a few chapters from now.

That's not a problem.

That's the process.

Cross things out. Add new ideas. Change your mind. Make another copy and start again if you want to.

This isn't a test, and nobody is grading your answers.

We're simply trying to notice what's already there.

So don't worry about figuring out exactly how you're going to make something happen yet.

We'll get there.

For now, let's start with a much better question:

What might be worth moving toward?

— *Chase*

Is This Guide for You?

You don't need to be starting over to benefit from asking better questions about where you're going. This guide may be especially useful if:

- **You're questioning your current path** — whether you're established in a career, facing a transition, approaching retirement, or simply wondering if there's something else you'd rather be doing.
- **You've tried different opportunities** — online or otherwise — but still haven't found a Direction that feels like yours.
- **You're a creator, entrepreneur, or small-business owner** wondering whether your interests, skills, or experience could open possibilities you haven't considered.
- **You're a student, young adult, or parent** thinking about college, a major, career choices, or whether the traditional path still makes sense for the future ahead.
- **You're an educator** interested in helping students think beyond simply choosing a job and toward understanding their strengths, Direction, and the possibilities available to them.

Or maybe nothing is wrong at all. You simply have a feeling there may be something more worth exploring.

What About the Digital Part?

Digital communication plays an important role in *Brighthaven Bay*. Through the college class, the novel explores websites, social media, video, online communities, and other ways people can communicate with audiences far beyond those immediately around them.

But that doesn't mean everyone needs to start an online business.

Digital tools might help someone promote a church fundraiser, build support for a local cause, share artwork or music, teach something they know, help an existing business reach more customers, or bring people together around something that matters to them.

The tools can help you reach people. What you choose to do with that reach is up to you.

For some, that may eventually include building an online business or creating income around something they care about. That's possible, too. But meaningful results usually require focus, consistency, patience, and a clear sense of where you're trying to go.

That's why we're starting with Direction—not the tools.

Before You Look for the Next Opportunity

The central idea is simple: tools follow clarity. First identify what matters to you and the Direction that fits. The practical tools can wait until you have something worth pointing them toward.

What this guide will help you do

- Notice the interests and activities that consistently pull your attention.
- Identify skills, experience, knowledge, and creative strengths you may be undervaluing.
- Recognize problems, people, or causes you naturally care about.
- Look for patterns where your interests, strengths, and concerns overlap.
- Identify two or three possible Directions without forcing yourself to choose too soon.
- Create a working Alignment Map you can revisit as your thinking develops.

Important: This is an exploration guide, not a promise of income or a prescription to leave secure employment. The goal is greater clarity — not a rushed decision.

1. Start With What Pulls You

Repeated curiosity is information. Pay attention to what you return to when nobody is assigning it to you.

WRITE WITHOUT JUDGING THE ANSWERS

What subjects do I read, watch, talk, or learn about even when I don't have to?

What activities make time pass quickly for me?

What did I enjoy before practicality, schedules, or other people's expectations took over?

If I had one free Saturday every week, what would I naturally want to spend part of it doing?

Look for energy, not just hobbies

An interest does not have to become a business. The point is to notice where your energy already goes. Gardening may point toward teaching, design, sustainability, local food, photography, or community. Music may point toward performing, instruction, production, storytelling, or helping other musicians. The first answer is rarely the only answer.

What patterns or repeated interests do I notice in my answers?

Which of these interests gives me the most energy right now?

2. Inventory What You Already Have

People often look outward for a new opportunity before taking inventory of what years of life have already given them. Your useful assets may include formal skills, practical experience, relationships, hard-earned lessons, creative ability, or knowledge you consider too ordinary to count.

Four kinds of assets

- Skills — things you can do: organize, repair, design, teach, write, sell, cook, build, coach, photograph, analyze.
- Experience — industries, jobs, projects, family roles, volunteer work, setbacks, transitions, or challenges you understand firsthand.
- Knowledge — subjects people already ask you about or things you know how to explain simply.
- Creative strengths — art, music, storytelling, graphic design, photography, writing, crafts, video, decorating, or other forms of expression.

What do people regularly ask me for help with?

What have I learned to do well over the years?

What have I experienced that could help someone a few steps behind me?

What creative abilities or ideas have I never seriously explored?

3. Notice What You Care About

Meaning often appears where ability and concern overlap.

Who do I naturally want to help?

What problem bothers me enough that I wish someone would solve it?

What change would I be proud to contribute to?

What kind of work would still feel worthwhile even if nobody was impressed by it?

Find the overlap

Look back at the first two sections. Circle or note anything that appears more than once. A recurring theme can be more useful than a dramatic revelation. A possible Direction often lives where these meet: what interests you + what you can contribute + who or what you care about.

What themes keep appearing, and where do my interests, strengths, and concerns seem to overlap?

4. Turn the Pattern Into a Direction

You do not need a perfect life-purpose statement. You need a Direction clear enough to keep exploring.

DIRECTION STARTERS

I’d like to use my ability to _____ to help _____

I keep coming back to _____ because _____

I would like to explore whether my experience with _____ could become _____

If I could build meaningful work around one part of my life, I would start with _____

Keep it broad enough to discover

“I need to start a YouTube channel” is a tool decision. “I want to help first-time gardeners grow food in small spaces” is a Direction. The clearer the Direction becomes, the easier it will eventually be to judge which tools belong — and which do not.

Possible Direction #1:

Possible Direction #2:

Possible Direction #3:

5. Notice What May Be Possible Now

The world around us has changed. Ideas that once required a large organization, specialized gatekeepers, expensive infrastructure, or access to a major city can sometimes be explored today in ways that were not practical for earlier generations.

You do not need to choose the tools yet. For now, simply allow yourself to notice where an old assumption may no longer be true.

What have I assumed was unrealistic, impractical, or “too late” for me to explore?

Which part of that assumption might be worth questioning today?

If cost, location, age, credentials, or technical confidence were less limiting than I assumed, what might I want to explore?

What possibility feels more believable to me now than it did a few years ago?

Stop here on purpose. You do not need to decide how to build any of these ideas yet. The purpose of this page is to widen the field of possibility without letting the tools choose the Direction for you.

6. Possibility Examples

These are not prescriptions. They show how the same discovery process can point people in very different Directions.

Creative: An artist may discover that the real pull is not simply “making art,” but helping people make their homes feel personal. A musician may realize the strongest energy comes from teaching beginners rather than performing. A graphic designer may discover a particular kind of client or cause they care deeply about.

Practical skill: Someone experienced in home repair, landscaping, bookkeeping, cooking, or auto restoration may discover that the deeper Direction is teaching, solving a recurring problem, serving a particular community, or improving how an existing service is delivered.

Life experience: Someone who has navigated a career change, cared for aging parents, rebuilt after a setback, relocated, or mastered a difficult process may possess useful perspective they never considered valuable.

Existing business: A local business owner may discover that the answer is not a new business at all. The Direction may be strengthening the business they already care about, communicating its value more clearly, or serving customers in a more meaningful way.

Which example — or variation of one — makes me think differently about my own Direction?

What other possibilities do these examples bring to mind for me?

7. Choose What Deserves More Attention

Clarity can grow before action. You can learn a great deal simply by deciding what deserves closer attention.

Look at the possible Directions you wrote earlier. You do not need to commit to one. Choose the idea that creates the most curiosity, energy, or sense of meaning right now.

The Direction I most want to keep exploring is:

What about this Direction feels meaningful or energizing to me?

What would I want to understand better before making any decisions?

What signs should I pay attention to as I continue reading Brighthaven Bay?

Your assignment for now: notice. Pay attention to the characters, conversations, and choices that make you stop and think about your own answers. Let the story challenge your assumptions before you rush into implementation.

8. Your One-Page Alignment Map

Bring the strongest answers from the guide onto this page. You are not signing a contract with your future. You are creating a working map.

CALLING — What keeps pulling at me?

STRENGTHS — What skills, experience, knowledge, or creativity can I bring?

PEOPLE / PROBLEM — Who or what do I care about helping?

DIRECTION — What path seems worth exploring?

POSSIBILITIES — Which two or three possibilities deserve more attention?

QUESTION TO CARRY FORWARD — What do I most want to understand as I continue?

[illegible]

“The answers we’re looking for don’t always arrive when we ask the question. Sometimes they show up later—in a conversation, a quiet moment, or a story we weren’t expecting to see ourselves in.”

— Chase Carter

A FINAL NOTE FROM CHASE

Keep This Guide Close

You've reached the end of the guide.

But I hope you don't think you're supposed to have everything figured out.

You're not.

Maybe one Direction is beginning to stand out.

Maybe you've narrowed ten possibilities down to three.

Or maybe all you've discovered is that something you've been ignoring for years deserves another look.

That's enough.

Clarity rarely arrives all at once.

It develops as you pay attention.

So keep this guide nearby as you continue through *Brighthaven Bay*.

When something in the story makes you stop and think, come back to it. Look at what you wrote. Add something. Cross something out. Ask yourself whether an answer still feels true.

And if your Direction changes?

Good.

It means you're learning something.

There's one other thing I want you to resist.

Once you begin seeing possibilities, it's tempting to immediately start looking for the tools, platforms, technology, or opportunity that will make everything happen.

Don't worry about that yet.

There's a reason we started with you.

The tools available today are extraordinary. They can make things possible that would have been difficult, expensive, or completely unrealistic not very long ago.

But a powerful tool can't tell you what matters to you.

It can't decide what kind of life you want.

And it can't choose your Direction.

Direction comes first.

Once you begin to understand where you're going, the tools become much easier to evaluate—because instead of asking *What can this tool do?*, you can ask a much more useful question:

Can this help me get where I want to go?

That's a question we'll save for another time.

For now, keep reading.

Keep noticing.

Keep questioning.

And keep this guide somewhere close.

When the time comes, I'll show you where to go next.

I'll see you in Brighthaven Bay.

— *Chase*



Consider this your invitation to Brighthaven Bay. Visit BrighthavenBay.com to step into the story, explore Brighthaven Bay, and continue the journey you've started here.

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